Ancient Glue May Have Helped Neanderthals Fight Germs

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Neanderthals were ancient humans who lived long ago. They made a sticky glue called **birch tar** by heating the bark of birch trees. They used it to stick stone points onto wooden handles to make tools.

Now scientists think **birch tar** may also have been used as **medicine**.

Researchers from universities in Germany, England, Belgium and Canada made their own **birch tar**. They used old methods, like heating bark in a sealed pit in the ground, or burning bark next to a stone.

Then they tested the tar on germs. Every sample slowed the growth of a type of **bacteria** that often infects **wounds**. Some of these germs are hard to stop with modern **medicine**.

There are other clues, too. People around the world have used **birch tar** as **medicine**, and **Neanderthals** used plants and cared for each other. The team leader, Tjaark Siemssen, said there is growing evidence of **medicine** use among **Neanderthals**.

Word Treasure

Neanderthals -- Ancient humans who lived a very long time ago.
birch tar -- A sticky glue made by heating birch tree bark.
bacteria -- Tiny living things; some can make you sick.
wounds -- Cuts or injuries on the body.
medicine -- Something used to help people heal or feel better.

Background you need

Neanderthals were ancient humans who made stone tools.

Birch tar is a sticky glue made from the bark of birch trees.

Scientists sometimes copy old ways of making things to learn how people lived long ago.

Break it down

WHO: Neanderthals long ago, and scientists led by Tjaark Siemssen today
WHAT: Birch tar, an ancient glue, slowed germs that infect wounds
WHERE: Researchers at universities in Germany, England, Belgium and Canada
WHY: To learn whether Neanderthals may have used birch tar as medicine

Why it matters

It shows that people long ago may have found clever ways to care for cuts, just like we use bandages today.

Test what you remember

1. Who made birch tar long ago?

- (A) Astronauts
- (B) Dinosaurs
- (C) Robots
- (D) Neanderthals

2. What is birch tar made from?

- (A) Rocks
- (B) Birch tree bark
- (C) Milk
- (D) Sand

3. What did Neanderthals use birch tar for?

- (A) To cook soup
- (B) To build boats
- (C) To paint pictures
- (D) To stick stone points onto wooden handles

4. What happened when scientists tested the tar on germs?

- (A) Every sample slowed the germs
- (B) Nothing happened
- (C) The germs grew bigger
- (D) The tar turned blue

5. Which countries were the researchers' universities in?

- (A) Germany, England, Belgium and Canada
- (B) Only the United States
- (C) Egypt and India
- (D) Japan and Brazil

6. Who led the team?

- (A) Lígia Coelho
- (B) Tjaark Siemssen
- (C) Kevin Fennessy
- (D) Jim Vessella

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Tjaark Siemssen: Says there is growing evidence that Neanderthals used medicine.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):